National
Qualifications
2026

2026 Music

Advanced Higher

Question Paper Finalised Marking Instructions

These marking instructions have been prepared by examination teams for use by Qualifications Scotland appointed markers when marking external course assessments.

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General marking principles for Advanced Higher Music

Always apply these general principles. Use them in conjunction with the detailed marking instructions, which identify the key features required in candidates' responses.

(a) Always use positive marking. This means candidates accumulate marks for the demonstration of relevant skills, knowledge and understanding; marks are not deducted for errors or omissions.

(b) Where candidates are asked to identify a number of answers from a list of options, and they identify more answers than required award marks according to the detailed marking instructions for that question.

(c) Do not accept any answer that is not in the marking instructions. Use your professional judgement when candidates' responses do not exactly match marking instructions but carry the same meaning, for example plagal cadence/IV–I, plainchant/plainsong.

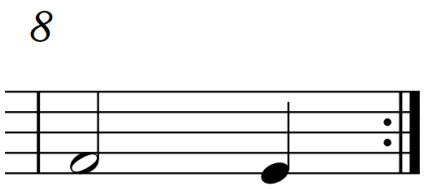
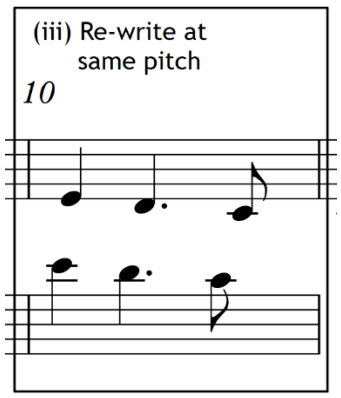
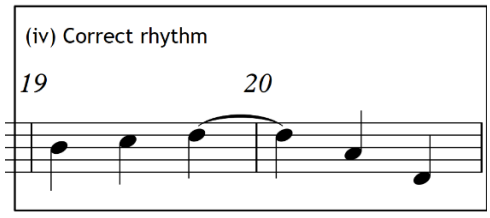
(d) Multiple-choice questions ask candidates to tick one or more boxes. Accept a cross or any other sign which makes the candidate's intentions clear.

(e) Use your professional judgement when deciding if candidates' written notation is sufficiently accurate or not.
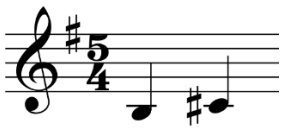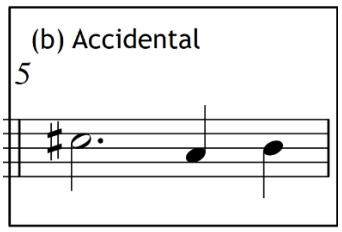
(f) Accept inaccurate spelling where the candidate's intention is clear.

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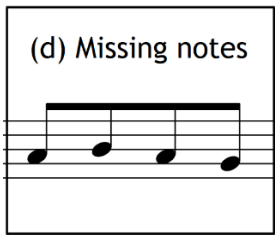
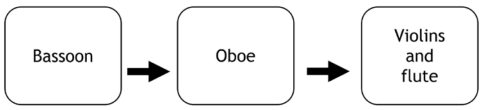
Marking Instructions for each question

Question			Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
1.	(a)		Ballett Countertenor Polyphonic Suspension	**4**	**1 mark** for each correct answer. Candidate responses can be listed in any order. Do not accept other answers.
	(b)		Motet	**1**	Do not accept other answers.
	(c)		Coloratura	**1**	Do not accept other answers.
2.	(a)	(i)	D major	**1**	Also accept D **or** D maj.
		(ii)		**1**	The repeat sign should be inserted accurately. Double bar line to be added to end of bar 8 with two dots in spaces 2 and 3 to the left of the double bar. Accept if also written correctly at the start of bar 1 **in addition** to above.
		(iii)		**1**	All notes (pitch and rhythm) must be correct for **1 mark**. Accept the stem in any direction and on either side.
		(iv)		**1**	The tie should be accurately placed between the last note of bar 19 and first note of bar 20. Accept the tie written either above or below the notes.
	(b)		Diminished 7th	**1**	Also accept dim 7th. Do not accept diminished on its own.

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Question			Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
	(c)		Bm or VI Em or II D 1st Inv or Ib	1	All chords must be correct to gain the mark. Also accept: B minor Also accept if candidate includes root or 'a'. Also accept: E minor Also accept if candidate includes root or 'a'. Also accept: D/F# D Maj/F# D Maj 1st Inv I 1st Inv Roman numerals and Arabic numbers (1,2 etc.) are accepted.
3.	(a)		Piano trio	1	Also accept chamber group. Do not accept chamber music.
	(b)		Dominant 7th	1	Also accept dom 7th.
	(c)		Contemporary jazz	1	Do not accept other answers.
	(d)	1.	Augmented triad	1	Also accept augmented **or** aug.
		2.	Syllabic	1	Do not accept other answers.
		3.	Tremolando	1	Also accept arco **or** tremolo.
		4.	Octave	1	Also accept 8ve **or** 8th.
4.	(a)			1	The time signature should be written after the key signature. Do not accept answers written as a fraction.
	(b)			1	The sharp sign should be placed in the space immediately **before** the C. Do not accept the sharp sign written after the note.
	(c)		Augmented 4th **or** tritone	1	Also accept aug 4th. Do not accept 4th **or** augmented on their own. Do not accept diminished 5th.

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Question			Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
	(d)			**1**	All notes (pitch and rhythm) must be correct for **1 mark**. Accept stems in either direction and on either side.
5.	(a)		Appoggiatura Modulation Sonata Subject	**4**	Do not accept other answers.
	(b)		Option 4	**1**	Do not accept other answers.
	(c)		Harmonic minor	**1**	Do not accept other answers.
	(d)		Option 3 	**1**	Do not accept other answers.

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Question			Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
6.	(a)	(i)			If the candidate chooses to write headings, do not penalise for concepts written under the incorrect heading. Long lists of concepts unrelated to the music and/or extensive lists of contradictory concepts will result in penalties being applied.
			Melody/harmony/rhythm:	**1**	Accept any **two** concepts for **1 mark**.
			Accents		Also accept sfz.
			Anacrusis		
			Countermelody		
			Diminished 7th		
			Dominant 7th		
			Dotted rhythms		
			Imperfect cadence		
			Minor **and** major		
			Modulation **or** change of key		
			Perfect cadence		
			Simple time **or** 4/4 **or** 2/4		Do not accept 2 or 4 beats in a bar.
			Syllabic **and** melismatic		
			Trill **or** appoggiatura		
			Tritone		Also accept augmented 4th or aug 4th.
			Texture/structure/form/timbre:	**1**	Accept any **two** concepts for **1 mark**.
			Arco **and** strings		Also accept arco **and** string orchestra. Do not accept orchestra on its own.
			Fugue		Also accept fugal.
			Harpsichord **or** basso continuo **or** organ		
			Homophonic **and** polyphonic		Also accept homophonic **and** contrapuntal. Do not accept homophonic **or** polyphonic **or** contrapuntal on their own.
			Imitation		Do not accept antiphonal.
			SATB		Do not accept chorus **or** choir **or** mixed voice choir on their own.
			Solo tenor		Also accept solo baritone. Do not accept tenor **or** baritone **or** solo male voice on their own.
			Stretto		
			Subject **or** answer		Also accept countersubject.

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Question			Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
		(ii)	**Melody/harmony/rhythm:**	**1**	Accept any **two** concepts for **1 mark**.
			Accents		Also accept sfz.
			Countermelody		
			Dissonance **or** discord		Also accept cluster.
			Glissando		
			Inverted pedal		
			Major		
			Modulation **or** change of key		
			Perfect cadence		
			Sequence		
			Simple time **or** 4/4 **or** 2/4		Do not accept 2 or 4 beats in a bar.
			Syllabic		
			Syncopation		
			Time changes		Also accept irregular time signature(s).
			Texture/structure/form/timbre:	**1**	Accept any **two** concepts for **1 mark**.
			Arco **and** pizzicato		
			Cymbal(s) **or** harp **or** xylophone **or** snare drum		Also accept side drum. Do not accept drumkit.
			Female chorus		Also accept soprano(s) **and** alto(s) **or** SA **or** female choir **or** female voices. Do not accept SATB chorus.
			Homophonic **and** polyphonic		Also accept homophonic **and** contrapuntal. Do not accept homophonic, polyphonic **or** contrapuntal on their own.
			Imitation		Do not accept antiphonal.
			Orchestra		
			Ostinato		
			Solo soprano		Also accept solo mezzo-soprano. Do not accept soprano **or** mezzo-soprano **or** solo female voice on their own.
			Staccato		
			Through-composed		
			Trumpet(s) **or** French horn(s)		Also accept fanfare. Do not accept horn(s) on its own.
			Unison		

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Question			Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
	(b)	(i)	Answers should focus on: • **melody/harmony/rhythm** • **texture/structure/form/timbre** This should be a written description of what is heard and not simply a list of similarities/differences.	**4**	**4 marks** Six similarities/differences. **3 marks** Four or five similarities/differences. **2 marks** Two or three similarities/differences. **1 mark** One similarity/difference. Accept any combination of six similarities/differences. If a candidate correctly identifies a similarity/difference but also includes a contradictory statement, annotate the correct answer with a tick and the contradictory statement with a cross. Do not award the mark. Where no extended answer is provided, that is simply a list, **a maximum of 2 marks** only can be awarded for this part of the question.
			Similarities 1. Accents 2. Countermelody 3. English text 4. Imitation 5. Homophonic **and** polyphonic 6. Modulation **or** change of key 7. Perfect cadence 8. Simple time **or** 4/4 **or** 2/4		Similarities may be written in any order. Also accept sfz. Do not accept antiphonal. Also accept homophonic **and** contrapuntal. Do not accept 2 or 4 beats in a bar.
			Differences 1. Excerpt 1 is **SATB chorus**. Excerpt 2 is a **female chorus**. 2. Excerpt 1 features a **solo tenor**. Excerpt 2 features a **solo soprano**.		Differences may be written in any order. Do not accept chorus **or** choir **or** mixed voice choir on their own. Also accept soprano(s) **and** alto(s) **or** SA **or** female choir **or** female voices. Also accept solo baritone. Do not accept tenor **or** baritone **or** solo male voice on their own. Also accept solo mezzo-soprano. Do not accept soprano **or** mezzo-soprano **or** solo female voice on their own.

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Question	Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
	3. Excerpt 1 is **minor and major**. Excerpt 2 is **major**.		Do not accept strings **or** Baroque orchestra **or** small orchestra **or** chamber orchestra. Also accept full **or** large orchestra. Do not accept orchestra on its own.
	4. Excerpt 1 is a **string orchestra**. Excerpt 2 is a **symphony orchestra**.		
	5. Excerpt 1 uses **syllabic and melismatic** word setting. Excerpt 2 uses only **syllabic**.		
	6. Excerpt 1 uses **arco**. Excerpt 2 uses **arco and pizzicato**.		
	Excerpt 1 only Anacrusis Diminished 7th Dominant 7th Dotted rhythms Fugue Harpsichord **or** basso continuo **or** organ Imperfect cadence Stretto Trill **or** appoggiatura Tritone		Also accept fugal **or** subject **or** answer **or** countersubject. Also accept augmented 4th or aug 4th.
	Excerpt 2 only Cymbal(s) **or** harp **or** xylophone **or** snare drum Dissonance **or** discord Glissando Inverted pedal Ostinato Sequence Staccato Syncopation Through-composed Time changes Trumpet(s) **or** French horn(s) Unison		Also accept side drum. Do not accept drumkit. Also accept cluster. Also accept irregular time signature(s). Also accept fanfare. Do not accept horn(s) on its own.

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Question			Expected response	Max mark	Additional guidance
		(ii)	**Conclusion** Excerpt 1 is from the **Baroque** period. Excerpt 2 is from the **20th century** period. **Suggested justifications** **Excerpt 1** is from the **Baroque** period because of the use of: • harpsichord **or** basso continuo • string orchestra • ornamentation • fugue • polyphony • diatonic harmony **Excerpt 2** is from the **20th century** period because of the use of: • symphony (**or** full **or** large) orchestra **and** prominent percussion (**or** cymbals **or** snare drum **or** xylophone) • dissonance **or** discords • syncopation **or** time changes **or** ostinato • angular melodic line with no clear phrase structure • a wide dynamic range • lyrics such as working women, sending a fax, squash club	**2**	**2 marks** Both periods must be correctly identified and justified to achieve **2 marks**. **1 mark** • both periods must be correctly identified to achieve **1 mark** **or** • one period must be correctly identified **and** justified to achieve **1 mark** **No half marks can be awarded.** Within each excerpt, if an additional incorrect period has been provided, discount the identification of the correct period when marking this question. Also accept 21st century **or** modern **or** contemporary. Justification for each period may be linked to answers from 6(a) **or** 6(b)(i). Do not accept strings **or** Baroque orchestra **or** small orchestra **or** chamber orchestra **or** orchestra on its own. Also accept trill **or** appoggiatura. Also accept fugal. Also accept contrapuntal. Also accept tonic and dominant **or** the use of clear cadence points. Do not accept orchestra on its own. Also accept side drum. Do not accept drumkit. Also accept cluster. Also accept irregular time signature(s).

[END OF MARKING INSTRUCTIONS]

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